

THE RIVER SUTRA

This account of a journey down the Ganga meanders from scientific concern to religious sentiment



GANGA
by JULIAN CRANDALL HOLLICK
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■ By Sam Miller

Many aeons ago, India was an island. It moved slowly northwards across the southern oceans, and eventually crashed into Asia. The two landmasses buckled where they met, and the result, some 50 million years ago, was the Himalayas. The sea that had separated the continents, known to scientists as Tethys, disappeared. The great plain of the Ganga marks its prehistoric position.

There are many incredible stories told about the Ganga, both by scientists and in Hindu scripture. And it's very hard to distinguish truth from fiction. British radio producer Julian Crandall Hollick travelled down the river, from Gaumukh to Sagar, a gently meandering journey of 2,500 km and attempted to unravel its mysteries. In his book (and in a radio series) he tries to find out what, if anything, is special about the Ganga—and whether this polluted, depleted river is in danger of dying.

The Ganga that he describes is much more (and occasionally less) than a river. It is both a goddess and a latrine—sometimes for the same person. It is a source of life, and a bringer of death; a provider of food, of energy, and it is a means of transport. It has numerous avatars, as a Himalayan stream, a dried up river-bed, a raging monsoon torrent, and a slow-moving estuary merging into the Indian Ocean. Crandall Hollick, like many of the pilgrims he meets, feels that the Ganga holds some unexplained power over him, that the “river never stopped calling” to him. He implores sceptics to take seriously the belief that *Ganga jal* has health-giving properties, and shows how western and Indian scientists have found significant, if not wholly conclusive, evidence of the Ganga's special powers.

Crandall Hollick is never on his own. He travels with scientists, pilgrims, researchers, drivers and oarsmen as he makes his way down the river, in a series of broken journeys, on foot, by road and by boat. He tells everyone he meets that he cannot understand “if Indians worship Ganga as sacred, how can they also pollute her so off-handedly”. In Varanasi, he gets half an answer, when a woman tells him, “She is our mother... Isn't it normal for kids to shit in their mother's lap? Oh, children will be naughty, but a mother is a mother. Mothers always

pressive trickle. The Tehri dam and the Farakka barrage are both condemned as foolhardy human interventions, which have depleted the Ganga, and caused permanent damage to the environment.

Ganga is an attractive book, with helpful maps and informative footnotes that accompany Crandall Hollick and his readers as he heads towards the Bay of Bengal. The author hurries the second half of his journey—and we hear little, for instance, about two of the biggest cities he passes, Patna and Kolkata. At times, he also gets lost in a

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HOLY MOTHER: Ganga is much more than a river; it is a goddess and a latrine

clean their kids. We cannot pollute a mother.” The author argues that “Ganga can be ‘dirty’ but not ‘polluted’ in the eyes of the faithful”.

By the end of his scatological journey, Crandall Hollick is no longer very worried about pollution. He believes in the ability of the Ganga to purify and regenerate herself. The greatest threat is that the Ganga might actually disappear, run out of water. Simply too much water is extracted for domestic, industrial and agricultural purposes—and in places what was once a magnificent river has been turned into an unim-

soup of religion and science, of yagnas and bacteriophages—and forgets to tell us about what he sees and hears and smells, or about the more recent history of the river and those who dwell alongside it. But Crandall Hollick is an engagingly informal writer; his prose gently meandering like the Ganga, as he addresses a broad range of issues that affect the future of the river, with genuine concern and commitment. He is pessimistic but never quite loses hope, and rightly insists that if the Ganga dies, we only have ourselves to blame.